nation in the Western Hemisphere as an attack by the Soviet Union on the United States requiring a full retaliatory response upon the Soviet Union.'[4]

The President demanded the prompt dismantling and withdrawal of all 'offensive' weapons from Cuba and called upon Premier Khrushchev 'to halt and eliminate this clandestine, reckless, and provocative threat to world peace and to stable relations between our two nations.'[5] One pre-eminent scholar of the missile crisis, James Blight, has described Kennedy's near eighteen-minute address as, 'the scariest speech ever given'.[6]

Nikita Khrushchev had previously threatened nuclear war against the United States. In July 1960 he declared that 'Soviet artillerymen can support the Cuban people with their rocket fire should the aggressive forces in the Pentagon dare to start intervention against Cuba.' He claimed, 'we have rockets which can land precisely in a preset square target 13,000 kilometers away.'[7] In reality, the Soviets possessed only four first-generation ICBMs at this time, none of which had anywhere near the accuracy of which Khrushchev boasted.

In 1960 Khrushchev had not the slightest intention of using these missiles on behalf of Cuba. Nor had he any intention of revealing how few ICBMs the Soviets possessed. The Soviet Premier was aware of Soviet quantitative inferiority (and would soon become aware of their qualitative inferiority). That awareness was not shared by officials in Washington. During the Eisenhower presidency, there was widespread anxiety that the Moscow was moving ahead in strategic nuclear weapons, first in bombers ('the bomber gap') and then in ICBMs ('the missile gap'). Paucity of intelligence, analytical misjudgements, inter-service rivalry, and congressional pressure, all contributed to overestimation of Soviet capabilities.

In September 1961, however, a National Intelligence Estimate (NIE 11-8/1-61) made clear the missile gap was, in essence, a myth. It explained that new electronic and satellite intelligence (corroborated by human intelligence) enabled a more realistic appreciation of Soviet ICBM capabilities. Electronic data from Soviet ICBM tests provided information on new types of ballistic missiles. Most significantly, between June and August 1961, the Corona satellite programme 'provided the first positive identification of long-range ballistic missile deployment complexes, has